

RESPONSIBLE TECH SHOULD NOT WAIT FOR REGULATION TO MANDATE IT

Technology forces us to be mindful about ensuring it equally benefits all. This approach to ‘responsible tech’ relies on business leaders, as decision makers, to not assume that their deployment of technology is a neutral decision and to validate that their use of technology doesn’t exclude or disadvantage anyone.

BYLINE BY: SATISH VISWANATHAN, HEAD OF SOCIAL CHANGE FOR THOUGHTWORKS IN INDIA

A recent MIT report titled, ‘The state of responsible technology’ sponsored by Thoughtworks shares findings that support the investment of effort and resources in responsible tech. 73% of the survey’s respondents believe, “responsible technology considerations will eventually come to equal business or financial considerations in importance when organizations make decisions about technology use.”

Responsible tech in India

Companies operating in India have a significant responsibility to bridge the digital divide with solutions that are suited to low resources and incorporate multilingual features for better accessibility.

Interestingly, the biggest concerns when it comes to tech in India is cybersecurity and privacy and data integrity. This is where adequate adherence to data protection laws and regulations will help protect the privacy of citizens and companies operating in India.

In India, most businesses are highly motivated by government regulation. This might be because the onus for defining ‘responsibility’ in the context of technological innovation often falls to governments and regulators. Also, responsible technology frameworks are perceived to be deeply ingrained in company culture and operations. Particularly for larger organizations in India, emphasizing on digital literacy and fostering a responsible tech-focused

community is critical to continued enablement of ‘good tech.’

It wasn’t long ago, in 2020 that India became one of the founding members of The Organization for Economic Co-operation and Development or OECD’s multi-stakeholder initiative - Global Partnership for Artificial Intelligence (GPAI), which has the goal of “guiding the responsible development of the AI, grounded in human rights, inclusion, diversity, innovation, and economic growth.”

What’s next in responsible tech?

Our vast global experience and longtime commitment to ‘tech for good’ ultimately led us to publish our Responsible Technology Playbook to help other organizations. Responsible technology goes beyond a hypothetical or a buzzword – it is a concrete business consideration across industries.

Leaders should consider how responsible tech policies could impact brand perception among customers, investors, vendors, and partners. Organizations should adopt a more serious approach to how their employees, both current and future, view their use and creation of technology. And forward-looking business leaders, at both small and large companies, should expect that responsible technology, and practices related to environmental sustainability in particular, will continue to grow in importance.

An interesting case study is India’s largest brokerage firm,

Zerodha and its views on user engagement. A widely read blog, written by their CTO, Kailash Nadh states, “There is great irony in software specifically created for stealing attention, profiling user behaviour and mining private data to sell ads, touting user centricity and showcasing sophisticated technology for maintaining privacy.” His idea is that, when we combine software with a viable business model to meaningfully solve problems – our conviction in the software’s usefulness will organically acquire users and gradually create a sustainable business – this approach will drastically reduce the likelihood of creating user-hostility. And he says, “this clarity brings on things that truly matter—quality and utility of software.”

As the understanding of responsible technology continues to evolve and mature, further nuances are likely to emerge. Organizational motivations are not always sufficient to overcome barriers to change or aligned with how responsible technology practices actually manifest. This is perhaps unsurprising: As companies dig into how to make existing operations more responsible—or build responsible technologies from the ground up—they may uncover unanticipated benefits, challenges or areas of opportunity. We expect the overall trajectory of responsible technology – and its potential to change the world for the better. If leaders are able to recognize that while algorithms can scale up problems massively and exacerbate inequality massively, they can also do the opposite.